

Figure 4: New notification system



Figure 5: The new KRunner layout

the application descriptions below their names. The option to run the apps as a different user is also back, which was available in the KDE3 series, but went missing in KDE4. Also, the addition of the help button (the ? icon) gives the user an idea of the different syntaxes that we can use. Earlier, it more or less depended on guesswork.

The Dolphin file manager now shows a slideshow of the images that are inside when you hover over a folder when using the file 'Preview' mode. A feature to play (preview) media files in the 'Information' pane has also been added.

The optional tree-view is back in **System Settings**, reminiscent of KControl from KDE3, for those who need it. A major bug fix, I'd say, is the ability to configure items that require root-level changes (like, for example, KDM) from within **System Settings**. Any option that required root privileges used to be greyed out earlier—now it prompts for a root password instead. Also, PolicyKit has been integrated into the desktop and a module is made available here. With this you can fine-tune certain privileges. Like, for example, Dolphin usually lists all available partitions in the side pane, whether an entry has been set in the `/etc/fstab` file or not. However, in previous KDE versions,

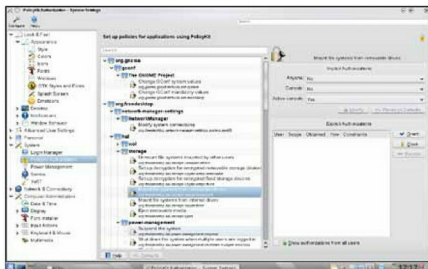


Figure 6: System Settings using the Classic Tree View layout (see left panel); fine tuning PolicyKit settings (right)



Figure 7: Image preview in Dolphin file manager

trying to access such a partition would result in a **Not permitted** error message. Now if you set the settings correctly in the PolicyKit module, you can give a normal user the privilege to mount these partitions.

All these are small add-ons, which makes 4.3 more of an incremental update rather than a major overhaul like its predecessors. There are, of course, numerous other enhancements; I've only listed the ones that drew my attention.

The most impressive factor is the overall stability of the applications and Plasma, and thereby the stability of the desktop as a whole. However good KDE4 has been till date, it's always been a tad unstable

compared to its predecessor or alternative desktop environments. Having used 4.3 since the RC1 release, I've hardly faced crashes. And when it does crash, the crash report tool has a button to restart whatever has crashed—provided it's a KDE app.

The news is that work had already started on version 4.4 much before 4.3 was released; so expect many new additions in the version that comes out next January. **END**

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